Resilient University Information System

Final project report · Fault Tolerance and Dependable Computing
Aibyn Talgatov (CSE-2505M)
Repository: https://github.com/a169n/final_fault (full report: `reports/final/REPORT.md`)

Key results

13 / 13	scenarios passed by the final configuration in all 3 repetitions, against 1 / 13 for the baseline
6.8 s	until payments resume after the database primary is stopped, with no operator; 0 acknowledged payments lost in 9 failovers
99.76 %	availability over a ten-minute soak with nine component faults, against 85.30 % (baseline, one run)
77 %	of destroyed payment records restored from backup in about 2 s; the baseline lost all of them

1. Introduction and system

The project continues the university information system of the midterm and endterm (students, payments, transcripts, timetables). The endterm left two gaps: the database primary was a single point of failure for every payment, and nothing protected the data itself. The final closes both, states measurable objectives first, and computes reliability figures from the experiments.

One codebase, two configurations. Every container runs the same image. The **baseline** has the same replicas and standby but nothing uses them; **final** switches every mechanism on. Topology, workload, fault injection and monitoring are identical, so a measured difference is caused by the mechanisms.

Tier	Components (new in the final marked *)
Entry	nginx on :8080, failover between two gateways
Gateways	gateway ×2: JWT check, policy, rate limit, retry, timeout, breaker, ejection, stale cache
Services	auth, student ×2, payment ×2, timetable ×2, transcript
Data	PostgreSQL ×2 with synchronous* streaming replication; db-controller* (promote, fence); db-backup* (verified dump every 15 s)
Monitoring	Prometheus with 11 alert rules (5 new*), Grafana, one exporter per database node*

19 containers on one Docker host. Critical workflow: client → nginx → gateway → payment → database → standby.

2. Requirements and dependability objectives

#	Objective (target)	Final, measured	Met
SLO-1	Availability under one fault ≥ 99.5 %	100 % in five scenarios, 99.76 % in the soak; 98.81 % (E2) and 97.95 % (E5)	partly
SLO-2	Payments resume ≤ 10 s without an operator	6.8 s (E2), 5.9 s (E5)	yes
SLO-3	p95 latency ≤ 1 s, also at 11× load	40–48 ms; 680 ms at 110 clients	yes
SLO-4	0 duplicate charges, 0 acknowledged payments lost	0 / 0 in 36 runs with a component fault	yes
SLO-5	Destroyed data: loss window ≤ 20 s, restore ≤ 60 s	3.8–13.7 s; 2.0–2.5 s	yes
SLO-6	Alert ≤ 10 s (down), ≤ 15 s (errors), ≤ 20 s (records lost)	5–8 s; 12 s; 5–6 s	yes
SLO-7	100 % of unauthorized requests denied and audited	189 of 189	yes

SLO-8	A standby streams again after the repair	12 of 12 runs	yes

Assumptions. Crash, omission and timing faults and one destructive operator statement; no Byzantine faults; one fault per redundancy group; one Docker host; clean database stops; synthetic data.

3. Fault model, threat model and failure analysis

Terminology (Avižienis et al.): a *fault* is the cause (a killed container), an *error* the deviating state (a payment row left pending), a *failure* the deviation seen at the interface (a 5xx, a lost payment). Each scenario injects a fault; the event log shows the errors; the client log shows whether a failure occurred.

Failure mode	Baseline effect	Tolerance in final	Final effect
Replica or node crashes	its share of requests fails until repaired	health check, retry, restart policy	none
Gateway dies	total outage	nginx fails over to the second gateway	none
Replica slow (3 s)	throughput collapses	timeout, retry, outlier ejection	9 % throughput
Payment crashes mid-way	pending forever; re-send charged twice	idempotency key, checkpoint, rollback	retry is safe
Database primary stops	every database request fails or hangs	promotion, writer discovery, synchronous replication	6–7 s without payments
Records destroyed	permanent loss	verified backups, merge restore	≤ 15 s of payments lost
Forged or missing token	accepted	authentication, authorization, audit	denied, audited
nginx or host down	total outage	none	total outage

Threat model (STRIDE over five trust boundaries, 21 accepted residual risks; `THREAT-MODEL.md`). New in the final: the controller's database role can promote and fence but cannot read a table; the backup role is read-only; a backup is merged only after its checksum, a trial restore and a ledger check pass.

4. Reliability engineering

Definitions. A *failed second* has fewer than 99 % successful requests; a *failure* is a run of failed seconds; D is their number; T the observation window.

```
MTTR = D / failures
MTTF = (T - D) / failures
MTBF = T / failures = MTTF + MTTR
A = MTTF / (MTTF + MTTR)
λ = failures / (T - D)
```

Worked example (soak, final, 3 runs): T = 1 800 s, 6 failures, D = 46 s. MTTR = 46/6 = 7.7 s; MTTF = 1 754/6 = 292.3 s; MTBF = 300.0 s; A = 97.44 %; λ = 12.3 per hour.

Soak (9 faults / 600 s)	baseline	final
Faults that became failures	8 of 9	6 of 27
Fault coverage	11.1 %	77.8 %
MTTR	18.5 s	7.7 s
MTTF	21.8 s	292.3 s
MTBF	40.3 s	300.0 s
A (failed seconds)	54.20 %	97.44 %
A (requests)	85.30 %	99.76 %

The fault rate is injected, not observed: MTTF and λ describe the system under this fault load. What transfers is MTTR, coverage and the ratio between configurations. For fully masked scenarios no failure was seen in 210 s, so only a bound holds: λ ≤ 51 per hour at 95 % confidence (rule of three). A series/parallel model with an **illustrative** component MTTF of 30 days gives 29.9 against 3.1 minutes of downtime a year; almost all of the remainder comes from nginx and the single transcript service.

5. Architecture and fault-tolerance implementation

Infrastructure (H1–H9)

Service replicas with load balancing; database replication with standby reads; restart policy; storage checksums; independent monitoring; redundant gateways; liveness/readiness split.

Automatic database failover (new). A controller probes both nodes every second. After 3 probes without a writer it promotes the standby, but only one that was in sync. A returning stale primary is fenced and rebuilds itself as a standby. Replication is synchronous while a standby streams.

Verified backups and merge restore (new). A dump every 15 s, checked and checksummed, 20 kept. The restore loads it into a scratch database, checks the ledger, then inserts only missing payments and recomputes balances.

Software (S1–S13)

Retry with exponential backoff and jitter (3 attempts); timeouts (0.8 s per attempt); circuit breaker (5 failures, 5 s); health checks (1 s); idempotency keys with a unique constraint; checkpoint and rollback; graceful degradation (stale reads, HTTP 203); fail-fast writes; job checkpoints; outlier ejection.

Writer discovery (new). Each service asks both nodes for their role twice a second and writes to the one on the highest timeline. A promotion starts a new timeline, so a stale primary loses everywhere without coordination.

Nested timeouts (new). Database wait 0.5 s < gateway attempt 0.8 s < nginx 5 s < client 10 s.

6. Monitoring, observability and security

Logs. One JSON line per event with service, mode, kind, level and request ID; the ID crosses every hop and cannot inject log lines. **Metrics** (scraped every 2 s): requests and latency per route, upstream attempts, breaker and ejection state, denials, stuck payments, and new: who accepts writes, streaming standbys, failovers, backup age, completed-payment count. **Alerts:** 11 rules with `promtool` unit tests; in final all expected alerts fired and no unexpected one in 39 of 39 runs.

Control	How it works	Proof
Authentication, authorization	scrypt passwords, 15-minute HS256 JWTs, role × route matrix, fail closed	unit tests; E9
Validation, rate limiting	closed models, body ≤ 16 KiB, token buckets → 429	unit tests; E10
Audit, least privilege	audit line per deny and payment; database roles without DELETE; controller role without table access	integration tests

7. Verification and experimental methodology

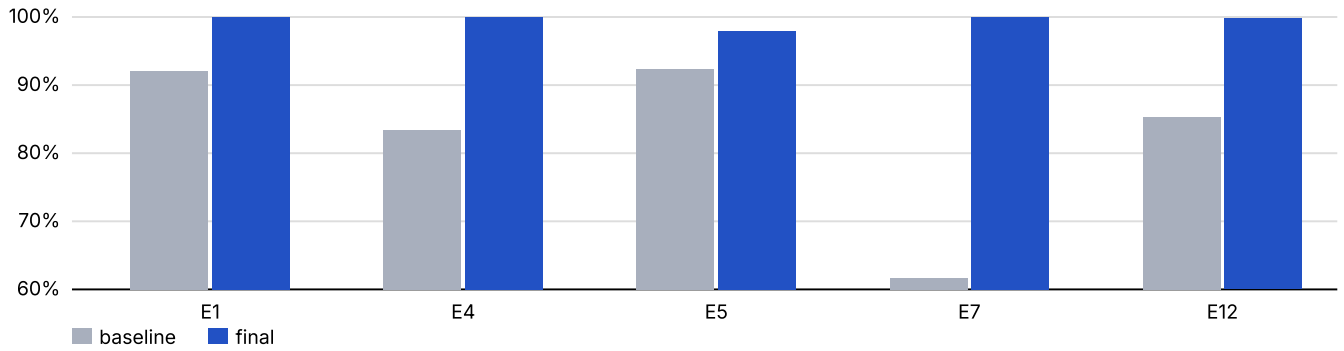
Each run restores a known state, applies a closed-loop workload of 10 clients (60 % reads, 20 % transcripts, 20 % payments, 20 % of payments re-sent), injects the fault at +20 s and repairs it at +45 s. Hypotheses and pass/fail criteria were committed before the results and are the same for both configurations. Test levels: 424 Python unit tests, 104 harness tests, 32 alert-rule cases, 22 integration tests (19 pass, 3 fail, see §9), 13 system scenarios.

8. Results: baseline against final

Code	Scenario	baseline	final	A base	A final	Dup. base	Dup. final
E1	Service process crashes	FAIL 0/2	**PASS 3/3**	92.04 %	100 %	658	0
E2	Database primary stopped	FAIL 0/2	**PASS 3/3**	99.29 % †	98.81 %	439	0
E3	One replica becomes slow	FAIL 0/2	**PASS 3/3**	100 % †	100 %	543	0
E4	A whole node dies	FAIL 0/2	**PASS 3/3**	83.37 %	100 %	452	0
E5	Payment interrupted mid-way	FAIL 0/1	**PASS 3/3**	92.37 %	97.95 %	222	0
E6	Load spike (110 clients)	**PASS 1/1**	**PASS 3/3**	100 %	100 %	463	0
E7	One gateway dies	FAIL 0/1	**PASS 3/3**	61.69 %	100 %	217	0

E8	Error spike (alert test)	FAIL 0/1	**PASS 3/3**	69.12 %	90.38 %	271	0
E9	Unauthorized access	FAIL 0/1	**PASS 3/3**	100 %	100 %	386	0
E10	Abuse and malformed input	FAIL 0/1	**PASS 3/3**	100 %	100 %	403	0
E11	Records destroyed, restore	FAIL 0/1	**PASS 3/3**	100 %	100 %	497	1 ‡
E12	Soak: nine faults	FAIL 0/1	**PASS 3/3**	85.30 %	99.76 %	2 076	0
E13	Database standby stopped	FAIL 0/1	**PASS 3/3**	99.99 %	100 %	376	0
	Scenarios passed	**1 / 13**	**13 / 13**				

"k/n" = repetitions in which every criterion passed. A = successful requests / all requests, mean. † flattered by hanging clients (§9). ‡ two acknowledgements for one payment whose record was destroyed between them; one row in the database. The baseline campaign was stopped by the deadline after 17 runs, so its values come from one or two runs.

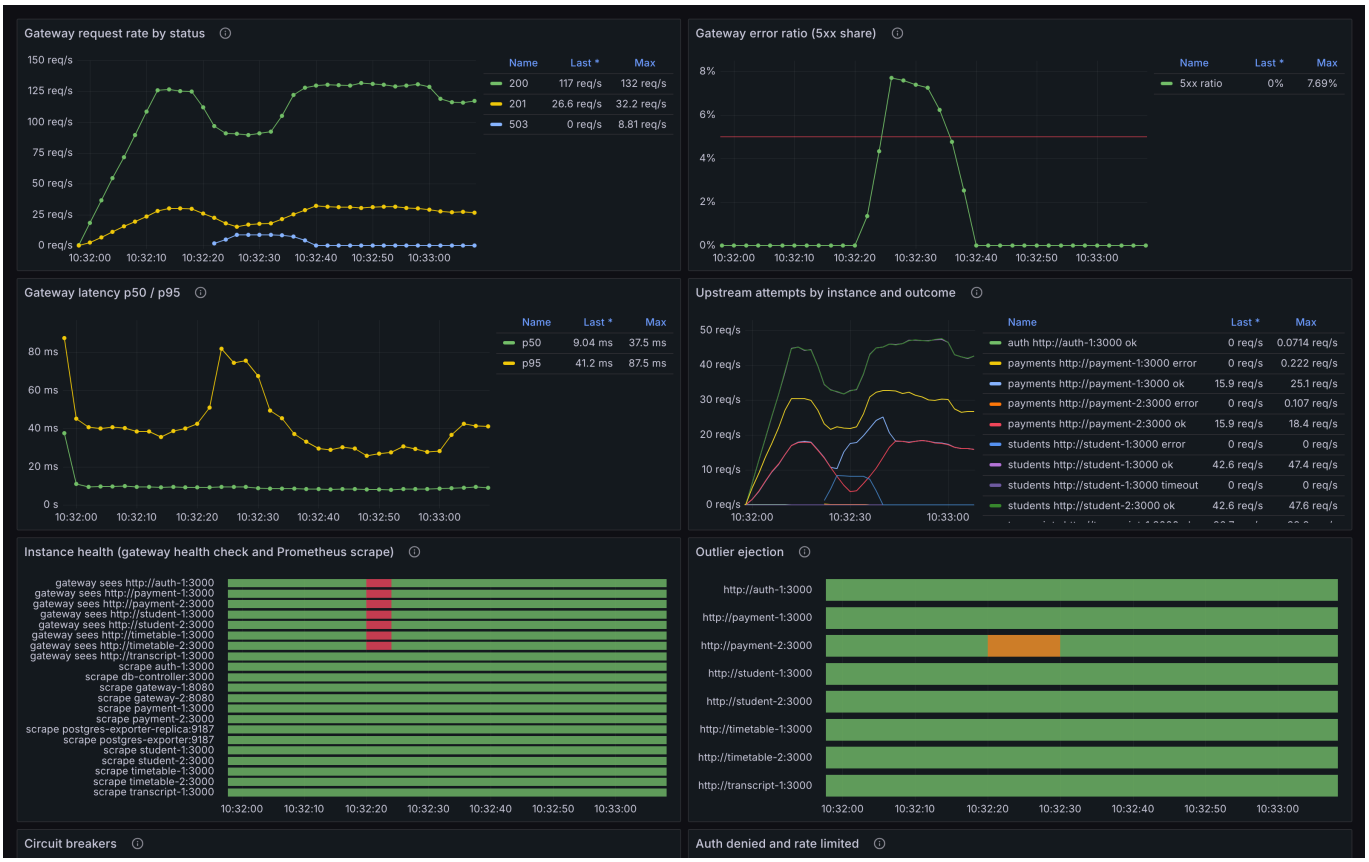


Request availability (axis starts at 60 %). Replica, node and gateway failures are masked completely; an interrupted payment (E5) still costs about 6 s of payments because the fault hits both payment replicas.

Key measurements

Measure	**baseline**	**final**
E2: payments succeed again after the fault	20.5 s, after the operator's repair	6.8 s ± 0.6 s, primary still down
E2: successful requests per second during the fault	1.4–1.8	125–133
E3: throughput kept during the fault	7 %	91 %
E9: attacks denied, of 63 per run	0; 41 attacker payments stored	63; none stored
E11: acknowledged payments missing after the repair	all 1 115	118–383 of about 1 140
E11: loss window / restore time	39.9 s / no backup	3.8–13.7 s / 2.0–2.5 s
E12: seconds with < 99 % success, of 600	240	14–16
Acknowledged payments lost in 9 automatic failovers	–	0

One incident end to end (E2, final run r1)



The primary stops at 10:32:20. Payments fail (503) while reads continue; the 5xx share peaks at 7.7 %. After three failed probes the controller promotes the standby; services find the new writer and the payment breaker closes. `DatabaseDown` fires after 8 s; `DatabaseNoWriter` never leaves pending because the promotion is faster.

9. Discussion, limitations and future work

Where final is worse or the evidence is weak

SLO-1 missed in E2 and E5. When one fault removes all capacity for payments, the system bounds the outage (6–7 s) and cannot mask it.

E2 availability: the baseline scores higher (99.29 % against 98.81 %) only because its clients hang and stop sending; it served 1.4–1.8 requests per second during the fault against 125–133.

E13 hypothesis refuted: stopping the standby was expected to stall payments for 2–4 s; no request failed, the slowest took 1.3–1.8 s.

Mechanisms interact: promotion takes about 4 s, but the payment breaker stays open 5 s, so payments resume after 6.8 s.

Limitations

Baseline: one or two repetitions, stopped by the deadline. An alert rule (`BackupStale`) misfires in the baseline, so its alert results are unusable.

Three of 22 integration tests fail against the final stack, undiagnosed.

One host; three repetitions; closed-loop workload; clean database stops only.

One controller with one vantage point; backups on the same host; nginx and the host remain single points of failure.

Lessons learned

Restoring "the latest" backup restored nothing: it was taken after the damage. Restore from before the incident.

Replication does not protect data from a wrong statement; only a backup does.

Measure availability more than one way; request counts hide a system that hangs.

A hypothesis that fails (E13) is as informative as one that holds.

One run was contaminated by the experimenter and repeated (`EXPERIMENT-LOG.md`).

Next steps

Fix the alert rule and complete the baseline; diagnose the failing tests; reset the breaker on a writer change; WAL archiving; a quorum-based failover manager; a second nginx and host.

10. Conclusion and references

The final configuration met seven of eight objectives and passed all 13 scenarios in every repetition; the baseline passed one. The database primary is no longer a single point of failure for payments, no acknowledged payment was lost in nine failovers, and destroyed records are recoverable to the last backup. The weak points are reported with the data that shows them.

References: final assignment (`docs/requirements/`); Avižienis et al., "Basic Concepts and Taxonomy of Dependable and Secure Computing", IEEE TDSC 2004; Nygard, *Release It!*, 2018; Beyer et al., *Site Reliability Engineering*, 2016; Shostack, *Threat Modeling*, 2014; Kleppmann, *Designing Data-Intensive Applications*, 2017; Trivedi, *Probability and Statistics with Reliability, Queuing, and Computer Science Applications*, 2002; Schroeder et al., "Open Versus Closed", NSDI 2006; PostgreSQL 16, nginx and Prometheus documentation.

Contribution

Aibyn Talgatov defined the scope of the final project from the assignment, directed the work, set the format of this report and manages the repository. The implementation, the experiment campaign and the drafting of the report were produced with an AI coding assistant (Claude Code) under that direction; changes were checked by automated tests. The system extends the team's midterm project.